Scandinavia, before reaching a black-out darkened London, where he decides to enlist.

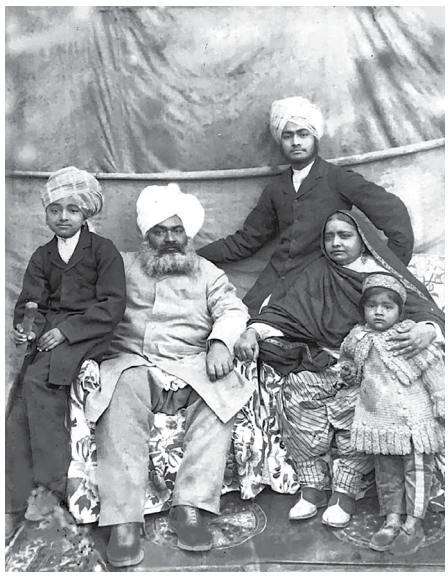
Lion of the Skies, written by Stephen Barker, an English WW1 historian, locates Malik's story in the struggle he undertakes to become a fighter pilot and be given due respect as a full officer of the King's military. Laid out here is yet another instance of the huge, racist double-standards of the Raj, where the high authorities are desperate for the dedication and sacrifice of their colonial soldiers, yet unwilling to grant even the most battle-proven desi officer a commission where he might give orders to a white man.

Following Malik's story, we get some funny and revealing bits. Once, when Malik is walking in Paris with an Algerian officer of the French army and a white *poilu* fails to salute the officer; the officer berates the soldier into saluting and the Sardar realises that the French cook their racism somewhat differently from the British. Then, working as an ambulance driver in the town of Cognac, the teetotaller Malik comes under the joint attention of the managers of two of the biggest brands of fine brandy, Hennessy and Martell, thus losing his aversion to firewater in one of the best ways imaginable. The passages where Malik finally goes into battle in a Sopwith Camel may disappoint readers of Biggles books, but they believably capture the stop-start, boredom-horror reality of war.

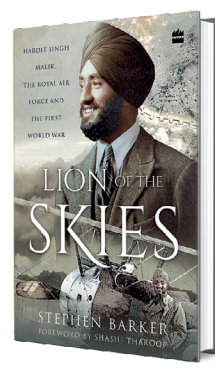
Returning to India after the war, Nariman Karkaria writes his fast-moving, often hilarious travelogue in Gujarati for a small subscribership. We have to be grateful to Murali Ranganthan for unearthing this gem and doing a superb translation. Karkaria puts down pithy, hilarious thumbnails: "Though there were only six Parsis in Peking, they were at daggers drawn!... one had to be mindful about encountering them while walking around the city." When Karkaria's unit is taken to the frontline in France, he describes the devastation a 15-inch artillery shell can cause, before going on to other ordinance: "...so these bombs, the latest invention of the white brain, were converted so that they could be used as rifle grenades."

Both books are invaluable reading for anyone interested in the encounter between a certain youthful subcontinental energy and the devastating short-circuits of the white brain from a hundred years ago. ■

–Ruchir Joshi



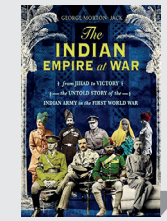
LION OF THE SKIES: Hardit Singh Malik, the Royal Air Force and the First World War
by Stephen Barker
HARPER COLLINS INDIA
₹599, 248 pages



THE LIST

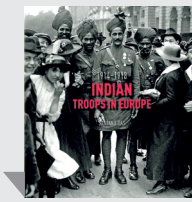
POINT OF HONOUR

How India fought the First World War



THE INDIAN EMPIRE AT WAR: From jihad to victory, the untold story of the Indian Army in the First World War
by George Morton-Jack
LITTLE, BROWN
₹699; 592 pages

The First World War took nearly two million Indians on many a journey. Most turned soldiers, some became prisoners of war, while others travelled as spies. This book collects their extraordinary stories.



INDIAN TROOPS IN EUROPE
by Santanu Das
MAPIN PUBLISHING
₹1,850; 160 pages

How did the Indian soldier survive Europe during the Great War? This visual record of Indians in the continent's trenches, fields, farms, billets, markets, towns, stations and hospitals offers some answers.



THE HALFMOON FILES (2007)
by Philip Scheffner (Director)

Indians interned in the German city of Wünsdorf during World War I were made to record their voices through phonographic funnels. This documentary allows us to again listen to their stories and anguish.